SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #23 · WORK AND IDENTITY

"Rest must be earned."

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Where it often comes from

Many of us grew up where rest was a reward for finishing everything, and the list never ended. Parents who worked without pause, jobs that praised overwork, or cultures that treat busyness as virtue can teach that rest is for people who have done enough. The result is guilt in every quiet moment and bodies that run on empty.

What Scripture teaches

God rested on the seventh day, not because He was tired but to set a pattern for us. The Sabbath command says six days we labor and on the seventh we rest. The psalmist says it is in vain to rise early and stay up late, toiling for bread, for He gives sleep to His beloved. Jesus invited His disciples to come away to a solitary place and rest for a while, and He said, "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest." Rest is a gift God gives and a command He gives, not a prize we win.

> *"And He said to them, 'Come with Me privately to a solitary place, and let us rest for a while.' For many people were coming and going, and they did not even have time to eat"* (Mark 6:31).

Also see

> "Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is a Sabbath to the LORD your God, on which you must not do any work—neither you, nor your son or daughter, nor your manservant or maidservant or livestock, nor the foreigner within your gates" (Exodus 20:9–10).

> "In vain you rise early and stay up late, toiling for bread to eat— for He gives sleep to His beloved" (Psalm 127:2).

> "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest" (Matthew 11:28).

> "And by the seventh day God had finished the work He had been doing; so on that day He rested from all His work" (Genesis 2:2).

Common self-statements

- I have not done enough to rest.
- If I stop, everything will fall apart.
- Rest is for lazy people.
- I feel guilty when I sit down.
- I will rest when everything is finished.
- Others are working while I rest.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I should always be productive.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that rest is wrong.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I either work constantly or I am lazy.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that if I rest, things will collapse.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that rest must be earned?
- What would actually happen if I took a real rest this week?
- What does God's own example of resting say to me?
- What is rest costing me when I refuse it?
- What does rest look like for me, such as sleep, a walk, a Sabbath, or time with friends?
- What could I let go of for one day?

Truth summary

> Rest is part of God's design for me, not a reward for finishing. He gives sleep to His beloved and invites the weary to come to Him. I can rest without guilt, trusting Him with what is not done.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Tired
- Sleep Problems
- Peace
- Anxiety/Worry
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Weak/Tired
- Prayer

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns
Honest distress can coexist with faith and hope in God.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Rest must be earned"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Rest must be earned." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me that rest must be earned?
- ☐ What would happen if I rested?
- ☐ What can wait?
- ☐ What does rest look like for me?
- ☐ How does guilt show up?
- ☐ What would it mean to trust God with the unfinished list?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Rest is a gift and a command.
- ☐ God rested and calls me to rest.
- ☐ The list will never be finished.
- ☐ I can rest and still be responsible.
- ☐ He gives sleep to His beloved.
- ☐ Rest is part of faithful work.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Mark 6:31
  "And He said to them, 'Come with Me privately to a solitary place, and let us rest for a while.' For many people were coming and going, and they did not even have time to eat."
- ☐ Psalm 127:2
  "In vain you rise early and stay up late, toiling for bread to eat— for He gives sleep to His beloved."
- ☐ Matthew 11:28
  "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Rest and guilt: Each day, write what rest you took and how strong the guilt was from 0 to 10.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Mark 6:31 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Jesus invites me to rest, so I can rest without guilt.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Tired" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Schedule a weekly rest. Choose a block of time when you will not work and protect it.
- ☐ Take one short rest daily. Ten minutes of quiet, prayer, or a walk, without a screen.
- ☐ Name what can wait. Write what truly has to be done this week and what can wait.
- ☐ Pray with Matthew 11:28. Ask Jesus for rest and read the verse slowly.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Rest must be earned": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A rest taken
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Rest must be earned.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, You invite the weary to come and rest. Forgive me for believing I must earn it. Teach me to rest without guilt and to trust You with what I cannot finish. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.